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**JAPAN'S SUNTORY SUNBORDS CLINCHED THIRD PLACE, COMING BACK FROM A TWO-SET DEFICIT TO TAKE THE NEXT THREE SETS, AGAINST HALKBANK**  
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the first two sets. Also, for the first time in this edition, a five-set thriller took place when Sada edged past Sunbirds, 25-21, 31-29, 28-30, 22-25, 15-12.

However, all did not go as planned for the Brazilian side in the next match as it lost 26-24, 25-18, 28-26 to Halkbank.

Halkbank, needing either a 3-0 or 3-1 win to enter the semis, pulled it off courtesy the combination and tactical understanding between French Olympic champion Earvin Ngapeth and Dutch captain Nimir Abdel-Aziz.

However, the over-dependence on the two led Halkbank to falter in the first two sets against Perugia before attempting a comeback in the third. Yet it narrowly failed, 25-14, 25-16, 31-29.

The other semifinal saw a power tussle between Sunbirds and Minas, with the former heavily reliant on Muserskiy. Minas also faced an unforeseen circumstance when its star player, Isac Santos, suffered a fall in the first set and was benched. Michael Sanchez and Marcus Vinicius Evangelista Coelho stepped up in Santos' absence to seal the fifth set and match, 22-25, 25-22, 28-30, 25-20, 17-15.

Sunbirds eventually clinched third place, coming back from a two-set deficit against Halkbank, to take the next three sets and win 17-25, 23-25, 25-21, 25-19, 15-12, much to the delight of the 1000-plus audience.

The day of the final saw a huge crowd, with many coming with handmade placards ready to cheer their favourite players and get an opportunity to get autographs.

Among them were two friends who had come with their families. The two played college-level volleyball during their days at Trichy National College. They came from Tamil Nadu to meet with their favourite players, which included Muserskiy and Alain Junior De

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**Apex predator:** Oleh Plotnytskyi was the most valuable player of the tournament and the best outside hitter. SUDHAKARAJAIN